release from all responsibilities in a conspiratorial manner.'4 Crestfallen, he shuffled back to his office, packed some personal papers, and bade farewell to his secretarial staff in an adjacent waiting room. The fact that Mielke, 'a colleague in a common task', became a fellow conspirator was particularly galling. 'That was not just going behind somebody's back anymore but was the preparation of an inner-party and state putsch,' he stormed. 5

Late on the evening of 17 October, he returned to Wandlitz looking tired. That same evening, he held a tortured phone conversation with Krenz to arrange the text of his resignation statement. The charade continued the next morning when he 'asked' the Central Committee to release him from the function of general secretary, just as Ulbricht had been forced to do two decades earlier. The full text of Honecker's resignation statement was tapped-out by ADN at 2pm on 18 October:

After mature reflection, and as a result of yesterday's consultation in the Politburo, I have come to the following decision: as a result of my illness and the operation I underwent, the state of my health no longer allows me to apply the strength and energy which the fortunes of our party and the people demand now and in the future. Therefore, I ask the Central Committee to release me from the function of General Secretary of the SED Central Committee, from the office of Chairman of the GDR State Council, and from the function of the chairman of the National Defence Council of the GDR. Comrade Egon Krenz, who is able and determined to meet the responsibility and extent of the work in the way required by the situation, the interests of the party and the people, and the preparations for the twelfth Party Congress, which encompasses all areas of society, is to be recommended to the Central Committee and People's Chamber.

Dear Comrades! I have devoted my whole conscious life in unshakable loyalty to the revolutionary cause of the working class and our Marxist-Leninist worldview, to the creation of socialism on German soil. The foundation and successful development of the socialist German Democratic Republic, the balance sheet of which we drew up on the 40th Anniversary, I regard as the culmination of the struggle of our party and my own work as a communist.